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A typology of the perceived risks in the context of consumer brand resistance

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Abstract

Purpose – This paper aims to provide a typology of perceived risk in the context of consumer brand resistance and thus answers the following question: how do consumers perceive the risk they take when resisting brands?

Design/methodology/approach – Two qualitative methods were used. In-depth interviews were carried out with 15 consumers who resist brands. An ethnography was carried out for ten months in an international pro-environmental NGO.

Findings – This multiple qualitative method design led to the identification of four types of risks taken by consumers. The four categories of perceived risks identified are performance (lack of suitable alternatives for the brand), social issues (stigma and exclusion), legal reasons (legal proceedings) or physical considerations (violation of physical integrity). These risks are located along a continuum of resistance intensity. Resistance intensity levels are avoidance, offline word-of-mouth, online word-of-mouth, boycott, activism and finally extreme acts.

Originality/value – This study provides a framework that integrates perceived risks within the context of brand resistance. The paper highlights extreme acts of resistance and questions the limits of such behaviors.

Keywords Perceived risk, Qualitative research, Ethnography, Consumer behaviour, Consumer resistance, Cause related marketing, Anti-branding

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

“The day we stop posting our discontent on the Internet and really decide to act (not demonstrations or silent marches but burning buildings or sinking whalers, and removing unscrupulous financiers from power), we will have finally understood how to change things. It’s time to begin a new revolution and carry out real punitive actions.” [Comment of a web user on a Non-Governmental Organization blog]

The construction of strong relationships between consumers and brands is one of the most commonly discussed subjects in brand-related literature (Fournier, 1998a). A great amount of research has been devoted to the study of “virtuous” consumer-brand relationships such as loyalty (Fournier and Yao, 1997; Oliver, 1999), attachment (Park *et al.*, 2010), commitment (Chaudhuri and Holbrook, 2002; Garbarino and Johnson, 1999) or trust (Chaudhuri and Holbrook, 2001; Morgan and Hunt, 1994). However, consumers can also behave antagonistically toward brands (Aaker *et al.*, 2004; Holt, 2002; Kozinets and Handelman, 2004; Thompson and Arsel, 2004), and publications describing these consumer behaviors of resistance and anti-consumption started appearing at the beginning of the 1990s (Fournier, 1998b; Peñaloza and Price, 1993; Roux, 2007). Recent examples illustrate this trend include Starbucks, who were boycotted when they opened a coffee shop that was prohibited to women in Saudi Arabia. Otherwise, PETA

(People for the Ethical Treatments of Animals) launched a campaign named *McCruelty*, and encouraged consumers to demonstrate in front of McDonalds restaurants. This phenomenon is still a hot topic for marketers. As illustrated in the above comment taken from a French Non-Governmental Organization (NGO) website, consumers can spread negative word-of-mouth (NWOM) through messages posted on the internet. However, some consumers want to go further and adopt a very confrontational approach that could have serious legal or physical repercussions.

The literature concerning this trend investigates three main issues, namely, why consumers struggle, how they resist brands and whom or what they are fighting. However, very few publications to date have considered the risks that these consumers take. Varman and Belk (2009) mention the difficulty of finding an alternative to Coca-Cola for Indian farmers wishing to boycott this global brand. Other publications describe how resistance may lead to financial and emotional issues for some of the consumers who avoid the traditional marketplace by adopting a voluntary simplicity lifestyle (Cherrier and Murray, 2007; Cherrier, 2008).

Although some authors do identify several types of risks in a consumption context (Bettman, 1973; Hoover *et al.*, 1978;

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Roselius, 1971), the existing body of literature purely addresses perceived risks in the context of consumption behaviors and decision-making for consumption. In comparison, the present study focuses on perceived risks in the context of resistance behavior and the decisions made against market entities, namely, brands. It aims to answer the following question: How do consumers perceive the risk they take when resisting brands? This question is addressed through the use of a multi-method qualitative approach composed of in-depth interviews and an ethnography of a pro-environmental activist group for ten months. The paper provides three main contributions above and beyond existing research:

- 1 It conceptualizes anti-brand behaviors as a continuum of intensity, from avoidance to extreme acts of resistance.
- 2 It displays a typology of the perceived risks faced by consumers who resist brands.
- 3 It provides NGOs (or any cause-related associations) with a better understanding of how consumers perceive the risks involved in their resistance behavior.

This paper is structured as follows: The first section provides a conceptual overview through presentation of the literature used to study consumer resistance, the consumer–brand relationship and perceived risks. The methodology used in this study is then detailed. A third section presents the findings and finally, the contributions, limitations and possible new research avenues of this study are discussed.

Conceptual overview

Consumer resistance

Consumer resistance is a complex and multifaceted phenomenon (Mikkonen and Bajde, 2013). Peñaloza and Price (1993) conceive consumer resistance as the way consumers set up appropriation strategies to counteract structures of domination. Roux (2007, p. 69) defines it as “a motivational state leading to variable manifestations of opposition and which is triggered by certain factors linked to corporate behaviors and marketplace practices”. The consumer adopts resistant behavior when he or she perceives a dissonance between his/her values and beliefs and the practices, discourses and logic of businesses and markets (Roux, 2007) and feel oppression or hegemony (Fournier, 1998b; Peñaloza and Price, 1993). Resistance also involves opposition to an entity, known as a resistance target (Roux, 2007; Fournier, 1998b). The resistance target could be the marketplace in general (Dobscha, 1998; Kozinets, 2002) or a specific entity such as a company, brand or organization (Holt, 2002; Kozinets and Handelman, 1998, 2004).

Consumers have a wide range of “tools” for resistance. Consumers may adopt alternative ways of life and avoid interaction with the marketplace by self-involvement in reducing their number of possessions, voluntary simplicity, or reducing their consumption levels (Cherrier and Murray, 2007; Cherrier, 2008; Dobscha, 1998; Moraes et al., 2010; Pentina and Amos, 2011). To resist a specific entity – a brand, firm or organization – consumers adopt specific behaviors such as brand avoidance (Lee et al., 2009), NWOM (Richins, 1983), boycott (Garrett, 1987; Klein et al., 2004; Sen et al., 2001) or activism (Kozinets and Handelman, 2004). These resistance behaviors may be a response to company misconduct (Davies and Olmedo-Cifuentes, 2016) and could be driven by negative

emotions such as anger, discontent or sadness (Antonetti, 2016; Romani et al., 2012).

Furthermore, some authors (Hollenbeck and Zinkhan, 2010; Pentina and Amos, 2011) distinguish passive/non-violent actions (e.g. voluntary simplicity, avoidance, frugality) from active/violent actions (e.g. boycotts, protests, shoplifting), whereas Fournier (1998b) describes resistance as a continuum that varies in intensity from passive to more active rejection behaviors. She identifies three stages of consumer resistance. The first step is avoidance. The next level includes minimization behaviors such as coping strategies and downsizing. The last step is active consumer rebellion. This active rebellion includes complaining and boycotting as well as dropping-out behaviors. This contestation may be individual or collective (Peñaloza and Price, 1993; Roux, 2007).

Consumer–brand relationship: for better or for worse

This paper is focused on a specific resistance target, namely, brands. Consumer–brand relationships are complex. A wide range of literature emphasizes the positive impacts of the consumer–brand relationship on behaviors toward the brand (Chaudhuri and Holbrook, 2002; Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; Morgan and Hunt, 1994; Park et al., 2010). Brand trust and the brand affect both have a positive influence on brand loyalty (Chaudhuri and Holbrook, 2001). Park et al. (2010) demonstrated that brand attachment has a positive impact on behaviors in favor of the brand, such as waiting to buy the brand rather than buying from a competitor, or defending the brand when someone spreads negative information about it. Consumers may also develop positive feelings towards brands (such as brand love), which also lead to pro-brand behaviors. Brand love not only leads consumers to spread positive word-of-mouth (Batra et al., 2012; Wallace et al., 2014) but also makes them loyal to brands and more resistant to negative brand information (Batra et al., 2012). Indeed, a preferred brand becomes part of the consumer’s identity and people naturally tend to resist negative information about themselves (Ahearne et al., 2005). Brand love also increases brand acceptance (Wallace et al., 2014), meaning that consumers are more likely to forgive any wrongdoing by a preferred brand. This literature shows that a positive consumer–brand relationship may help brands to avoid resistance behaviors.

However, another line of marketing research addresses antagonistic consumer relations with brands. Most anti-brand behaviors are driven by negative emotions such as brand hate (Hegner et al., 2017; Romani et al., 2015; Zarantonello et al., 2016), anger, sadness, worry or dislike (Romani et al., 2012). These behaviors are diverse and appear to vary in their level of violence: switching brands (Romani et al., 2012), avoidance (Lee et al., 2009; Hegner et al., 2017), complaining to third parties (Hegner et al., 2017; Johnson et al., 2011; Romani et al., 2012; Zarantonello et al., 2016), NWOM (Johnson et al., 2011; Kähr et al., 2016; Romani et al., 2012; Zarantonello et al., 2016), retaliation (Hegner et al., 2017; Kähr et al., 2016), protest (Zarantonello et al., 2016), activism (Romani et al., 2015) or even illegal activities such as theft, threats and vandalism (Johnson et al., 2011). However, marketing literature does not mention other forms of consumer resistance such as “burning buildings”, “sinking whalers” or carrying out

“real punitive actions”, which are beyond the type of resistance that is traditionally studied in consumer research. These behaviors are investigated in sociology by authors such as Shepherd (2002), who studied the viewpoint of members of a radical environmental group. Johnson *et al.* (2011) describe illegal actions as anti-brand behaviors. It is therefore important to integrate such extreme behaviors in our study.

Consumers pursue diverse objectives through these antagonistic actions. Indeed, Kähr *et al.* (2016) make a distinction between forms of instrumental aggression (such as retaliation, boycott or NWOM), which aim to restore equity and vent negative emotions, and forms of hostile aggression (brand sabotage), which aim to harm the brand. Brand resistance is driven by various motivations that could be classified in three main categories. First, consumers may not identify with the brand. This occurs when the brand image is incompatible with the individual’s identity (“identity avoidance”, Lee *et al.*, 2009). Here, the individual can have a negative perception of the brand image and does not identify with consumers of the brand (this is called the “taste system”, see Zarantonello *et al.*, 2016). In the second category, consumers resist a brand because it does not meet their consumption experience expectations (“experience avoidance”, Lee *et al.*, 2009; “violation of expectations”, Zarantonello *et al.*, 2016). Finally, a brand could be rejected because of its perceived immorality. Here, consumers resist the brand because of its values and associations (“moral avoidance”, Lee *et al.*, 2009) as well as the behaviours, actions and policies of its parent company (“company misconduct”, Zarantonello *et al.*, 2016). In this case, the consumer is concerned about the negative impact of a brand on the whole society. According to Zarantonello *et al.* (2016), this moral motivation is the main reason for anti-brand behaviour. Brands showing immoral behaviour are targeted by antagonistic consumer responses such as boycotts for environmental concerns (Garrett, 1987).

The present research focuses on a continuum of action against brands for moral reasons, and the associated risks for consumers. The following section reviews the typologies of perceived risks in consumer behavior.

Typologies of perceived risks in consumer behavior

“Consumers behavior involves risk in the sense that any action of a consumer will produce consequences which he cannot anticipate”. This definition (Bauer, 1968, p. 187) underlines the fact that consumers sometimes have to face unpleasant and unintended consequences, for instance when he/she has to face a purchase situation (Hoover *et al.*, 1978).

Authors have proposed different typologies of perceived risk. Bettman (1973) makes a distinction between inherent and handled risk. Inherent risk is the latent risk of a product class for a consumer, whereas handled risk is the “amount of conflict a product class is able to arouse when the consumer chooses a brand from a product class in his usual buying situation” (p. 184). According to Hoover *et al.* (1978), risk has two components: the “amount that would be lost” if consequences are unfavorable and the “degree of certainty” that these consequences will occur. For Taylor (1974), risk is composed of outcome and consequences. Each of Taylor’s components – outcome and consequences – may lead to Psycho/Social loss

and Functional/Economic loss. Roselius (1971) focuses on the losses which can occur in a product buying situation. He identifies four types of “losses”: time, hazard, ego and money. Time loss means that consumers have to spend time to adjust, repair or replace a disappointing product. Hazard loss arises when products are “dangerous to [consumer] health or safety when they fail” (p. 58). Ego loss is the risk that a consumer “feels foolish when he/she buys a product that turns out to be defective” (p. 58). Ego loss is also related to a social dimension, because other people can also make the consumer feel foolish. Finally, money loss is the financial expense necessary to repair the product or replace it by a satisfying alternative. Another typology includes five types of risks: performance, financial, social, psychological and physical (Jacoby and Kaplan, 1972; Kaplan *et al.*, 1974). Brooker (1984) retains these five elements and adds time as a further risk component. Financial risk refers to money loss, physical risk refers to safety as hazard loss, while social (social image) and psychological (self-esteem) risks correspond to ego loss (Table I).

All types of perceived risk contribute to an overall risk. The influence of each perceived risk on the overall risk varies according to the product category. For instance, life insurance mainly involves a financial risk, a pair of dress shoes is a social risk, toothpaste is a performance risk and vitamins are a physical risk (Jacoby and Kaplan, 1972). In a consumption context, companies manage perceived risks to avoid their negative impact. Indeed, performance and financial risks decrease the perceived value for money for consumers (Sweeney *et al.*, 1999).

This paper focuses on resistance to brands and examines a variety of resistance actions ranging from non-activist to activist resistance behavior. A multi-method qualitative design is used to explore risk perception in this context.

Methodology: a multi-method qualitative approach

A wide range of brand resistance behaviors is investigated to obtain a risk typology in a brand resistance context. The use of two complementary qualitative methods provided a comprehensive understanding of the phenomena of brand resistance in addressing all its facets. Multiple methods and multiple data sources strengthen the validity of findings (Hollenbeck and Zinkhan, 2010). This type of multi-method approach also improves the reliability of data interpretation (Arnould and Wallendorf, 1994; Jonsen and Jenh, 2009). In-depth interviews and an ethnography were carried out to understand how consumers perceive the risks they take when they resist brands. Data were collected by the first author during 2014.

In-depth interviews

In-depth interviews were used to investigate the perception of the risks involved in non-activist resistance behaviors. They were conducted with fifteen French respondents, of which ten were female and five were male (Table II). Respondents were aged between 20 and 71 years old and had different educational and professional backgrounds.

An interview guide for brand resistance experience was used to conduct the interviews. This guide deals with brand

Table I Typologies of perceived risk in consumer behavior

Type of risk authors	Time loss	Safety	Self-image	Social image	Money loss	Product failure
Roselius (1971)	Time loss	Hazard loss	Ego loss		Money loss	
Brooker (1984)	Time loss risk	Physical risk	Psychological risk	Social risk	Financial risk	Performance risk
Jacoby and Kaplan (1972); Kaplan et al. (1974)		Physical risk	Psychological risk	Social risk	Financial risk	Performance risk
Taylor (1974)			Psycho/social loss		Functional/economic loss	

Table II In-depth interviews: respondent profiles

Motivation	Name	Gender	Age	Occupation	Interview location and duration
Environmental concern	François	Man	57	Climatologist	Workplace, 52 mins
Environmental concern	Claudia	Woman	21	Student	Coffee shop, 30 mins
Environmental concern	Alicia	Woman	27	Unemployed	Coffee shop, 45 mins
Environmental concern	Anna	Woman	25	Unemployed	Public park, 60 mins
Environmental concern	Sophie	Woman	51	Personal carer	Public park, 47 mins
Animal mistreatment	Ambre	Woman	24	Student	Coffee shop, 50 mins
Animal mistreatment	Léa	Woman	20	Student	Coffee shop, 31 mins
Animal mistreatment	Marjorie	Woman	23	Unemployed	Home, 48 mins
Animal mistreatment	Nicolas	Man	30	HR manager	Coffee shop, 41 mins
Geopolitical issues	Geneviève	Woman	64	Magistrate	Home, 31 mins
Geopolitical issues	Georges	Man	71	Retired	Workplace, 53 mins
Geopolitical issues	Régine	Woman	60	Biology teacher	Coffee shop, 80 mins
Discrimination	Marc	Man	46	Asset manager	Workplace, 39 mins
Discrimination	Myriam	Woman	31	Social worker	Home, 35 mins
Commercial misconduct	Geoffrey	Man	24	Student	Workplace, 68 mins

resistance (targets, actions and motivations) as well as brand relationships (such as brand consumption before resistance or feelings towards brands before and after resistance). Respondents were free to express themselves on these topics, and the interviewer asked for more details when the respondents mentioned risk perception. The number of interviews was determined by the data saturation criterion: authors decided to stop interviews when they no longer provided new information to answer the research question. The 15 interviews were recorded and transcribed. Interviews mainly took place in the respondent's workplace or home, or in public places such as public parks or coffee shops. Their duration varied from 30 to 120 min (average duration: 47 min).

Respondents were selected on one main criterion: they resist at least one brand. They were mainly recruited through the authors' personal networks and the "snowball" method. They carry out non-activist resistance to brands, such as brand avoidance and negative word-of-mouth. Five of the respondents who were interviewed for their non-activist resistance to brands were also met during the ethnography.

Motivations to act against brands vary across respondents. Five main motivations for resistance are identified: geopolitical issues, environmental concerns, discrimination, animal mistreatment and commercial misconduct. Respondents differed in terms of resistance action type and intensity, providing a broad range of resistance experiences. For instance, Ambre boycotts and spreads negative word-of-mouth against cosmetic brands that use animal testing. Geoffrey avoids the Apple brand because of a perceived commercial misconduct.

Ethnography

An ethnographic approach was also used (Arnould and Wallendorf, 1994). As the present study seeks to identify the risk involved in activist brand resistance, participant observation was carried out in an activist group. The observed group is part of an international non-governmental organization (NGO) whose members are concerned by environmental issues. The aim of the group is to fight against entities such as brands, companies or organizations that are generally considered to have bad practices for the environment. This NGO leads four campaigns. Each is related to a specific theme: "agriculture", "climate", "forest" and "ocean". Some people in this group are highly confrontational with the brands targeted by the group's activities.

Activists were observed during their meetings, activities and training session for ten months, from January to October 2014. A total of twelve specific events were observed. Six meetings were attended (meeting no. 1 to meeting no. 6) in which the past campaigns of the group were reviewed and future actions were prepared. The first author then took part in five group activities. Each activity corresponded to one of the NGO's campaigns. Activities no. 1 to no. 4 concerned the "agriculture" campaign. This campaign consists of opposing the use of Genetically Modified Organisms (GMO) and bee-harming pesticides. For instance, activists stuck stickers on a supermarket floor during activity no. 1. They also handed out leaflets promoting Organic Agriculture to consumers. Activity no. 5 supported the "ocean" campaign against the use of fish-aggregating devices for intensive fishing. During this activity, activists asked people to sign a petition and handed out leaflets.

They also stuck adhesive labels to canned tuna in a supermarket. Observed activities mainly took place in supermarkets. Prior to these activities, a half-day training session was organized by the NGO to train new members. An experienced group member explained how the participants should behave on the field during a campaign.

A field book was used to report observations and comments during the ethnography, and photos were taken. As a multi-method approach is recommended to improve ethnographic interpretations (Arnould and Wallendorf, 1994), the NGO's blog was also consulted.

Ethnography is complementary to the in-depth interviews. First, it is a means to access activism and extreme acts of resistance. Indeed, although our interviewees were resisting against brands, they were not all involved in extreme acts. Second, observation makes it possible to identify the risks that consumers actually take in a real context, providing more information than verbal declarations. More detailed conversations with core members indicated how dangerous the extreme acts were. The core members are people who are strongly involved in the group organization and actively resist the brands that are targeted by the NGO. All the group members' names have been changed to ensure their anonymity.

Data analysis

Data analysis in qualitative research usually consists of preparing and organizing data, reducing them into themes through a process of coding and finally representing the data in figures, tables or a discussion (Creswell, 2007). This general procedure was followed to identify regular occurrences that offer insights into the nature of perceived risks in a brand resistance context.

Data were gathered (interview transcripts, field notes) and were analyzed following a constant comparative approach (Strauss and Corbin, 1990). In a first step, authors implemented an open-coding process, reading and segmenting the data into categories of information to general themes. Then, a more focused coding of the data within the previously identified themes was carried out. This axial coding provides insight into specific coding categories that relate consumer perceived risk in a brand resistance context. These themes were

confronted to the relevant literature. Finally, information from this coding phase is organized into a figure. Following Wolcott's (1994) advice, cases were compared (experiences of brand resistance), results were compared with a standard (typologies of perceived risks in consumer behavior), and results were presented in a figure (see findings below).

Findings

Brand resistance intensity continuum (BRIC)

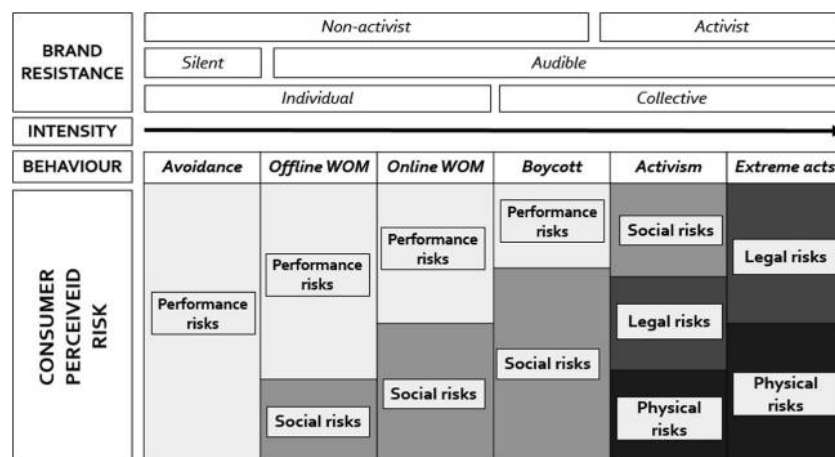
As mentioned in the literature review, consumer resistance varies in intensity (Fournier, 1998b). This study provides a new approach to the classification of resistance behaviors by constructing a framework to understand which types of risk are linked to the different anti-brand behaviors. This cannot be evaluated using Fournier's continuum, which is based on consumer resistance in general and not on brand resistance. The findings of this study show that perceived risks in a context of brand resistance arises along a Brand Resistance Intensity Continuum (hereafter referred to as BRIC, Figure 1).

The first step identified is identical to that of Fournier's continuum (1998b). Avoidance is the first anti-brand behavior identified: consumers avoid consuming the brand in question (Lee *et al.*, 2009). This is an individual and silent behavior.

An individual and audible anti-brand behavior then appears, namely, negative word-of-mouth (Richins, 1983). Consumers give their opinion of the brand to their other consumers or encourage them to not to buy it. A distinction is made between offline and online word-of-mouth. Offline word-of-mouth consists of face-to-face communications with family, friends, relatives, colleagues or acquaintances. Online word-of-mouth refers to messages posted on the internet, for instance on social networks or in personal blogs.

At the end of the continuum, three forms of collective and audible resistance were identified. Boycott is probably the most studied form of collective opposition (Klein *et al.*, 2004; Kozinets and Handelman, 1998; Sen *et al.*, 2001). It is defined as the collective rejection of trade with a specific entity to gain concessions or to express discontent with certain acts or practices of the target (Garrett, 1987). Finally, the explanations of core members of the activist group met during the

Figure 1 Perceived risks of consumers across the brand resistance intensity continuum (BRIC)



ethnography led us to make a distinction between activism (Kozinets and Handelman, 2004) and extreme acts.

In the light of our observation and discussion, activism was defined as situations of low confrontation (such as peaceful demonstrations to inform other consumers or obtain signatures for petitions). Extreme acts are highly confrontational interactions with the targets (such as emptying supermarket shelves, sticking campaign messages on products or shop floors, sawing through the roof and abseiling into a firm's general meeting or climbing up a crane). Examples of extreme acts are provided by the following article extract from the NGO's blog:

"Meanwhile, inside the room, two activists entered the general meeting by abseiling down through a hole in the ceiling, and installed two big banners with a similar message." ["Forest" campaign against Nestlé brand; article published in April 2010].

Other examples are provided by the ethnography. For instance, activists involved in activity no. 5 stuck adhesive stickers ('the good taste of carnage') on canned tuna in a supermarket without authorization to alert consumers about fish-aggregating devices. This is shown in photographs taken by the observer during this activity (Figures 2 and 3).

The BRIC concept can be defined as follows: involvement in an activity further along the continuum implies that the activist can also carry out the less violent activities of the range. For instance, someone who spreads negative word-of-mouth online can also talk negatively about the brand to close relatives, friends or colleagues. Following the same reasoning, a consumer who carries out extreme acts could also be involved in boycott and avoidance.

Figure 2 Example of extreme act: canned tuna with stickers glued onto them by activists (activity no. 5)



Figure 3 Example of extreme act (close up)



The risks perceived by resistant consumers

Consumers can perceive performance, social, legal and physical risks. These risks appear along the brand resistance intensity continuum described above. Each resistance behavior can involve several risks. Our findings on perceived risk by resistant consumers partially fit with the typology of Brooker (1984) and Kaplan *et al.* (1974), as illustrated below.

Performance risks: lack of suitable alternatives

Resisting a brand means at least avoiding the consumption of its products. This means that consumers have to find a suitable alternative for the rejected brand. According to Varman and Belk (2009), activists involved in the Coca-Cola boycott in India encourage consumers to look for alternatives to carbonated soft drinks. In a pamphlet, they point out the higher quality of local brands (such as *Thandai*, *Lassi*, *Rooh-Afza*), mentioning the "cheaper, tastier, and healthier alternatives" (Varman and Belk, 2009, p. 696) to the global brand. However, consumers may sometimes face a lack of suitable alternatives; this is referred to as a "performance risk". Generally speaking, consumers exposed to performance risks have to face a lack of satisfaction with the performance of the product or the brand (Brooker, 1984; Jacoby and Kaplan, 1972; Kaplan *et al.*, 1974). In the context of brand resistance, performance risk consists of a lack of suitable alternatives to the branded product.

Performance risks appear at the very beginning of the BRIC. Consumers who limit their action to avoiding brands are therefore only exposed to performance risks. In other words, people who decide to stop buying a brand may not find another brand that meets their expectations as well as the rejected one. In-depth interviews provide evidence of these risks, as illustrated by the following quotes:

I boycott Revlon, all Revlon products, except [...] You know, I permed my hair, about every two years. The only one that works and doesn't damage hair is made by Revlon. After two years, when I decided to do my perm and took an appointment, I felt sad because I was saying to myself [...] "if you use L'Oréal and so on, your hair will fall out [...]" And I say it, honestly, I'm reluctant to do it, but Revlon's not the most responsible of the brands causing trouble for Palestinians." [Régine, 60, biology teacher.]

My boycott of Coca-Cola lasted for six months [...]. After, I went back to my Coca zero addiction. Other brands taste bad! I gave in [...]. [Myriam, 31, social worker.]

Yeah, I buy Nike shoes, because they are good for running, so unfortunately there is just this brand. [Anna, 25, unemployed]

These three women are disappointed with the alternative brands for certain categories of products. Régine boycotts brands involved in the financing of the Israeli army, such as Revlon. But she is disappointed by other brands, such as L'Oréal. Myriam does not find alternative brands as tasty as Coca-Cola. Anna boycotts Nike for environmental reasons, yet she runs in shoes made by this brand. These examples illustrate the lack of suitable alternatives. Consumers who are not ready to face performance risks continue consuming the brand despite their initial resistance intentions.

Consumers also highlight the lack of suitable alternatives when the brand has some kind of monopoly over the market. In this case, performance risks refer to the lack of alternatives, or the difficulty to get an equivalent brand:

Honestly, buying one product rather than another doesn't bother anybody. When you have several brands, you can. It is harder when brands practically have a monopoly. [Geneviève, 64, magistrate.]

Performance risks are present in a large part of the BRIC, from avoidance to activism. The more the consumer is involved in the resistance continuum, the less they are affected by perceived risks of performance. In other words, performance risks decrease as the brand resistance intensifies. This phenomenon could be explained by the fact that the convictions of highly-involved people are stronger than their need to consume the brand.

Social risks: exclusion and stigma

In a consumption context, social risks are identified by several authors (Brooker, 1984; Kaplan *et al.*, 1974; Taylor, 1974). In a brand resistance context, social risks appear as soon as the resistance becomes audible. Those who spread negative word-of-mouth, whether on or offline, may therefore be exposed to social risks of exclusion and stigma. For instance, Geoffrey, who avoids Apple, does not spread negative word-of-mouth because he does not want to be perceived as a “*lesson-giver*” by people around him:

I often ask people, “You’ve got an iPhone, how much did you pay for it?” [...] It’s true that I try to be careful because I don’t want to be the “*lesson-giver*”, but it’s also true that I try to understand why they bought it” [Geoffrey, 24, student].

Alicia, who is committed to an environmentally friendly way of life and boycotts McDonald, described the difficulty she experiences when talking to others about it:

It’s not easy to convey ideas and explain why we’ll consume this or this when you are mocked, denigrated or excluded. [...] I don’t dare to discuss it, I speak about it gradually because I’ve got the impression that I will be judged negatively [...] You know? I would be classified as [...] I don’t know [...] an odd creature, someone strange.” [Alicia, 27, unemployed].

These quotes emphasize the risk of being stigmatized when spreading NWOM. Moreover, consumers are afraid of being excluded by their relatives, friends or family, as illustrated below:

I showed her [her best friend] documentaries, it was important, and she said that I had become resentful [...] Her judgment hurt me and from that day on, I have avoided speaking to people around me [Anna, 25, unemployed].

Social risks increase with the number of people perceiving the word-of-mouth. The number varies according to the means of communication used (face-to-face or internet), and this is why the present study distinguishes between offline and online word-of-mouth. For example, the messages posted on social media, as Ambre does, are visible by a wider audience:

I blog, I post [...] I post documentaries or articles on Facebook about the subject, and particularly for some brands [...] I try to inform, but unfortunately not everybody likes it because when you tell someone that what they’ve been doing for a long time is potentially dangerous for them, their kids and their health, it’s something they don’t want to hear. But I do it anyway.” [Ambre, 24, student].

Reactions to social risks are diverse. Geoffrey avoids social risks and remains silent. Alicia is cautious when she talks about her rejection of eco-unfriendly brands. The fear of rejection by others prevents Anna to speak freely of her resistance behaviors. People who spread word-of-mouth on line are less affected by the opinions of others. Amber is a good example because she “*does it anyway*”.

Legal risks: legal proceedings

The literature describing consumer perceived risk does not describe legal risks. This study defines legal risks as the possible prosecution of consumers as a result of their resistance behavior. Legal risks appear as soon as resistance becomes

collective. The consumers involved in the actions at the end of the BRIC are the most exposed to legal risks. The stronger the confrontation between activists and brands, the higher the danger of legal risks will be for participants.

Ethnography also provides insights into legal risks. Before each action, activists are given instructions to follow if they are arrested, such as how to behave with policemen or what to say when they are put in police custody.

“They mention that they know when they will leave, but they don’t know when they will return, because of the risk of arrest and custody.” [Field book extract, meeting no. 2].

During the ethnographic immersion, more detailed conversations were conducted with two group members: Doreen and Danny. They play a central role in the activist group. For instance, they welcome and train new group members. Danny managed media relations, while Doreen was responsible for actions against GMO (Genetically Modified Organism). Danny went to jail for three days in Sweden. He is currently under legal prosecution on several charges. Doreen was also taken to court and was condemned to a six-month suspended prison sentence. They participate in the more confrontational actions described as “*extreme acts*” in our BRIC. They could be called “*hardcore activists*”. Furthermore, the authors observed legal risks perceived by activists during the ethnography period:

Before starting the action, Danny brought us outside to give us some legal information in case “*things turned bad*”. We learned the rules for an identity check and custody. [...] He gave us instructions for custody. [Field book extract, activity no. 1].

In the car, everyone was afraid about the legal risks involved by the action. Claudia told us that she had done “*worse*” by participating in a project in Tricastin [French nuclear power station] where the police were obstructing the access to the power station. [Field book extract, activity no. 1].

Group members left the store quickly, but the manager of the supermarket refused to let Stephan go outside [...]. Later, the police were called. [Field book extract, activity no. 4].

These extracts illustrate the perception of legal risk by activists. The role of core members is to warn other activists about it and inform them about how to face legal risks. Moreover, activists are afraid about the legal proceedings involved in their resistance.

Physical risks: violation of physical integrity

Generally speaking, physical risks involve a lack of safety (Brooker, 1984; Kaplan *et al.*, 1974; Roselius, 1971). In a brand resistance context, physical risks are the last step in the risk that consumers have to face. Violation of physical integrity is associated with activism and extreme acts. During the ethnography, a supermarket employee threw shopping carts at activists. The core members told us stories about their past activities. Doreen climbed to the top of a crane and stayed there for several days:

In the car, Doreen told me that she had climbed to the top of a crane with two other activists during an action targeting a nuclear power station. [Field book extract, activity no. 1].

Danny stayed 13 h in the cold water of the Seine river in Paris (France). He was also punched in the face by a security guard during action in a supermarket. Some visitors on the NGO blog refer to physical risk; one web user refers to this danger in a comment, whereas other web-users talk about the “*courage*” of activists.

Don't forget that [NGO] need our donations and support to help them reveal all this: they are activists who take risks and often risk their life [comment from Bruno, on the NGO website concerning the "Forest" campaign against Nestlé brand].

"Congratulations to activists for their courage" [comment from Desruelle on the NGO website concerning the "Forest" campaign against Nestlé brand].

"Thanks for your courage" [comment from Bienraison on the NGO website concerning the "Forest" campaign against Nestlé brand].

The more the consumer is committed to active campaigns, the less he/she is afraid of risk. They perceived it, and are not only ready to face it but are proud to be involved in such extreme behaviors. Danny feels like a "superstar" and tells to his relatives that "they are lucky to know [him] because [he is] famous" [Field book extract, activity no. 3]. This desire to be over-exposed to risks is illustrated by the following field book extract:

During the previous campaign, Danny, who was worried about the risk involved for participants, did not stop repeating: "If someone has to get it in the neck, it should be me". [Field book extract, training session].

This quote also indicates that "hardcode activists" are aware of the physical risk for all group members.

Discussion and conclusion

Implications for theory and practice

This study aimed to provide a typology of perceived risks in the context of brand resistance. Using a qualitative multi-method approach, four types of risk were identified: performance, social, legal and physical. These risks arise along a BRIC composed of avoidance, offline word-of-mouth, online word-of-mouth, boycott, activism and extreme acts. This brand resistance continuum suggests that each resistance behavior can involve several types of risks. Avoidance, the only "silent" act of resistance behavior identified, corresponds to performance risk. Social risks appear as soon as the resistance becomes audible. People who spread word-of-mouth offline and online are exposed to performance and social risks. Consumers involved in boycott – the first collective form of resistance of the BRIC – are exposed to the aforementioned risks, plus legal risks. Taking part to activism therefore puts consumers at risks of exclusion and stigma, legal proceedings and violation of physical integrity. Finally, the people involved

in extreme acts are those who are the most exposed to legal and physical risks.

Conceptually, this paper provides a typology of perceived risks when consumers are resisting brands. There are some similarities and differences with existing typologies of risk used in the context of buying decision. As described in previous studies (Brooker, 1984; Jacoby and Kaplan, 1972; Kaplan *et al.*, 1974), performance, social and physical risks appeared. However, some discrepancies should be noted (Table III).

First, the word "performance" is not related to a product failure in this study, but rather to the lack of suitable alternative for the brand when it is rejected by consumers. Second, physical risk differs according to the consumer's degree of intent. Activists who are committed to extreme acts deliberately expose themselves to physical risks, whereas consumers seek to avoid this risk in the context of a product purchase. We can assume that consumers who are ready to face the risks involved in resistance behavior are capable of actions that are further along the BRIC continuum. This includes people who are not afraid of performance and social risks and are ready to spread NWOM. Moreover, this study describes types of consumer resistance such as extreme acts, which have rarely been studied in consumer research (Kozinets and Handelman, 2004; Johnson *et al.*, 2011).

In practical terms, this paper provides NGOs (or any other association fighting for a cause, such as animal welfare) a better understanding of consumer perception of the risks involved in their resistance behavior. In a consumption context, high risk perception may worsen consumer perception of a company's offer (Sweeney *et al.*, 1999). Following the same reasoning, perceived risk management appears as a crucial issue for any NGOs and associations taking anti-brand action. This paper provides NGOs and associations with a risk perception management tool to reduce perceived risks to encourage brand resistance. These findings reveal that people who decide to stop buying a brand may not find a satisfactory brand to replace the one they rejected. To reduce this performance risk, NGOs could recommend other brands as suitable alternative and thus help people to handle performance risk.

Furthermore, NGOs aim to mobilize consumers to act against entities such as brands, company or political organizations. This study can enable them to convince consumers to participate in the campaigns carried out by activist groups, such as signing petitions against brands,

Table III Typologies of perceived risk in a consumption vs a resistance context

Existing typologies	Proposed typology
Context	
Consumption context	Resistance context
Product category	Anti-brand behaviour
Types of perceived risks	
<i>Performance</i> : lack of satisfaction with the performance of the product or the brand	<i>Performance</i> : lack of suitable alternatives for the branded product
<i>Social</i> : social image degradation because of product consumption	<i>Social</i> : exclusion and stigma because of audible brand resistance
<i>Physical</i> : safety issues involved by the product consumption	<i>Physical</i> : violation of physical integrity involved by activist resistance
<i>Psychological</i> : self-image degradation because of product consumption	<i>Legal</i> : legal prosecution involved by activist resistance
<i>Financial</i> : money loss	
<i>Time</i> : time loss	

avoiding and/or boycotting them, etc. Convincing others to join resistance movements was indeed observed in our investigation. Other clients, who could be called “sympathizers”, supported activists during the actions. They were even encouraged to take part in the action by being photographed as they stuck the campaign message sticker on the brand product inside a supermarket or signed petitions against the brand. Here, we see that resistance may be contagious despite the risks involved.

Research perspectives

This research raises issues that consumer research could address in further studies. A new study of consumer perceived risk would make it possible to generalize these results to other activist groups. The replication of this method in other activist groups would show whether the same typology of perceived risk appears, such as animal mistreatment or gender discrimination.

Theory postulates that choice situations, such as buying decision, involve uncertainty. In turn, uncertainty creates anxiety. As anxiety is uncomfortable, consumers try to develop strategies to reduce the risk in the decision context to reduce the inherent anxiety (Taylor, 1974). Some authors focused on risk reduction methods (Roselius, 1971; Hales and Shams, 1991) and identified several “risk relievers” such as brand loyalty, major brand image, free samples and money-back guarantees (Roselius, 1971). A further study could be conducted to identify “risk relievers” in the context of brand resistance. In the present study, Régine tries to convince herself that Revlon was not the worst culprit to manage her cognitive dissonance (Festinger, 1957). In doing so, she reduces the distance between her beliefs (the brand must be boycotted) and her acts (consumption of this brand). Minimizing the guilt of the brand can therefore be assumed to help consumers manage performance risks by continuing to consume the rejected brand.

In addition, some forms of brand resistance were not evaluated. This study ignored online anti-brand communities, which are addressed in the literature (Hollenbeck and Zinkhan, 2010). Indeed, the NGO blog bears no similarity to an anti-brand community for a number of reasons. The website is not against a brand in particular but is opposed to a number of brands accused of harmful practices for environment. The interactions between web users are also limited, with not possibility to respond directly to a comment. Further studies could therefore address these unexplored issues.

The extreme acts described in this study remain understudied in marketing (Kozinets and Handelman, 2004; Johnson *et al.*, 2011). This type of resistant consumers is particular because these activists are the most exposed to risk, yet they are the least afraid. The identification of resistant consumers has already been investigated for people involved in the reduction of consumption (Cherrier and Murray, 2007; Cherrier, 2008). The identity of these resistant consumers should be investigated, as Ruiz-Junco (2001) did for activists in the Spanish Environmental Movement.

Finally, this investigation sheds new light on resistance boundaries. The reasoning is based on the following assumption: consumers who are ready to face the risks involved in an act of resistance are able to go further in the BRIC. In this study, the BRIC could be likened to a staircase in which each

step corresponds to a resistance behavior. A consumer who is involved in a higher step behavior will probably also use the lower step behaviors. In addition, the results suggest that each step involves one or more types of risk. Consumers who are ready to face the risks involved by anti-brand behavior are able to go further in the BRIC, i.e. move to the next step of intensity. For instance, boycotting a brand suggests that the consumer is also able to avoid it and to spread NWOM (offline and online) against it. A boycott involves performance and social risks. If the consumer is ready to face them, he is ready for the next step: activism. However, some activists involved in extreme acts seems do not be afraid of risks. So, what could be the limits of such resistance? And what are the limits for “hardcore” activists if they don’t feel afraid? As illustrated on the field or on the NGO blog, some people are ready to illegally enter private property, to commit acts of vandalism or directly attack people they consider to be guilty. Further investigations are required to understand such behaviors involving risks for others.

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